

development course, she was offered a hybrid job with a 2.5x hike over her last salary. Then there's Rohan Pahwa (name changed), who took a loan for his course, which cost ₹3.5 lakh. And it took him four months to find a job. Therefore, the ROI may be different in each case.

Kumar backs the ROI debate with some numbers. On average, learners at upGrad for such programmes join when they have an average annual salary of ₹8 lakh; the average increment they get after the completion of the programme is 50-55 per cent. In the case of Hero Vired, its website claims that the average salary hike for students who completed its online courses is 71.6 per cent. Edtechs argue that sometimes an ROI may not be immediate but may come in the form of a promotion six months down the line or the next job change.

Industry players also suggest ways in which people

to be advantageous for her career, she encountered a few stumbling blocks. "In my batch, there were people from different backgrounds and walks of life... Some people knew the fundamentals and wanted the teacher to move ahead quickly, but some were completely new and demanded the teacher explain a few concepts in-depth first." Her point was echoed by some other students of online executive programmes *BT* spoke with. Industry players believe that diversity is a blessing in disguise. "Within an edtech space, a CA, lawyer, and homemaker study under one roof. It is the biggest drawback and the biggest advantage as well," says Munjal.

Then there's the lack of personal touch and other irritants like multiple rescheduling of weekend classes and, sometimes, even their cancellation. Plus, unlike regular offline institutes, some providers of online

Courses start from ₹20,000 and go beyond ₹20 lakh for programmes that run from a week to three years. Tech courses like Generative AI and data science tend to be the most expensive

can ensure that their online course gives them a decent ROI. Kumar suggests that one must do basic research on what they will learn from the course, and how much hand-holding or support they will get from the edtech platform. Lakhamraju cites three metrics that Great Lakes uses to measure the effectiveness of its online executive programmes—student satisfaction, completion rate, and career outcomes. "Student satisfaction is measured throughout the course, after every class, interaction, and when the programme ends. When it comes to completion rate, it is important because if people don't complete a course, then they don't find it useful or the quality [of the course] is not good. Career outcomes are measured at different points after completion of the programme—six-, 12-, 18 months and beyond," he says.

Munjal says students have to ensure that they are serious about attending live classes and appearing for the required tests. Vyas of Deloitte echoes Munjal, saying a student's seriousness is an equally defining factor when choosing this route. Taking help from career counsellors and supervisors can also help, they add.

MEASURING UP

While an online executive course offers benefits such as ease and flexibility to students, are they better than offline ones? Arumugam says while the course turned out

courses don't offer placement support. "The company I did the course from played very little role in getting me placed. I had to find a job myself," says Pahwa. Vyas emphasises that placement is a decisive factor where offline channels have an edge over online channels. "Offline universities or players have some linkage to the job market. This is what online companies lack."

Industry watchers say offline executive programmes are a popular choice in India, and it would continue to stay that way. At the same time, online courses will also thrive. "Regulations have made it easier for institutions to offer online courses given the government's massive push on digital and its recommendations as part of the National Education Policy," says Damara.

upGrad's Kumar gives a sense of the direction upskilling edtech companies are likely to take. "We focus on fostering personal relationships through therapy and other means," he says, adding that students also need mentoring. At the macro level, he highlights why upskilling is important. "India has to provide talent for fuelling the global economy," he says.

For those looking to do an online management course and those offering one—these are interesting times indeed. **BT**

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